

# Hackers, The Class

(DRAFT)

## COMS 541

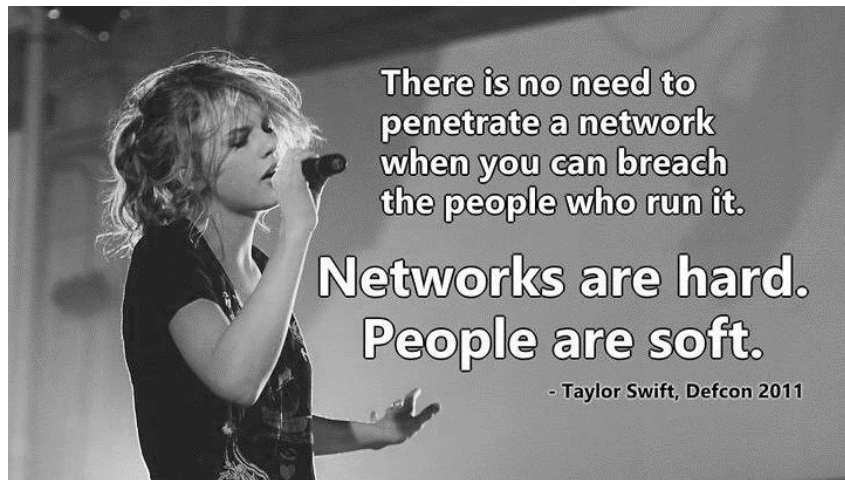
Department of Art History and Communication Studies, McGill University

Professor Gabriella Coleman — [gabriella.coleman@mcgill.ca](mailto:gabriella.coleman@mcgill.ca)

Tuesdays 9:35 AM - 12:25 PM in ARTS W-5

Office Hours = West Arts 285 by appointment

Fall 2016



### OVERVIEW

This course examines computer hackers to interrogate not only the ethics and technical practices of hacking, but to examine more broadly how hackers and hacking have transformed the politics of computing and the Internet more generally. We will examine how hacker values are realized and constituted by different legal, technical, and ethical activities of computer hacking—for example, free software production, cyberactivism and hacktivism, cryptography, and the prankish games of hacker underground. We will pay close attention to how ethical principles are variably represented and thought of by hackers, journalists, and academics and we will use the example of hacking to address various topics on law, order, and politics on the Internet such as: free speech and censorship, privacy, security, surveillance, and intellectual property. We finish with an in-depth look at two sites of hacker and activist action: Wikileaks and Anonymous.

### READINGS

Most readings are on our class website. The following books will be available at *Paragraph Book store*.

**Blogs and Twitter accounts you might want to follow:**

<http://www.wired.com/threatlevel/>

<http://lwn.net/>

<http://slashdot.org/>

<http://torrentfreak.com/>

## MOVIES

We will watch various short films and documentaries in class and you will be asked to watch some before class as well.

## LEARNER OBJECTIVES

This will allow us to 1) demonstrate familiarity with variants of hacking 2) critically examine the multiple ways hackers draw on and reconfigure dominant ideas of property, freedom, and privacy through their diverse moral codes and technical activities 3) broaden our understanding of politics of the Internet by evaluating the various political effects and ramifications of hacking. Students will be responsible for leading discussions on the readings and critically engaging the readings and class conversations.

## REQUIREMENTS, METHOD OF EVALUATION, AND ASSIGNMENTS

1. Class Participation 20%
2. Weekly Write up of Texts 30%
3. Final Assignment: A 20 page review essay based on readings from one class and the suggested readings (suggested readings tbd) 50%

### Final Essay:

Attendance at seminar is mandatory. If you have to miss the lecture, please arrange to get notes and any videos shown in class from a classmate. All cellphones, electronic devices, and wireless connections *must be turned off for the duration of class*.

## GRADING

### Grade Breakdown

| Grade point |  |
|-------------|--|
| 4.0         |  |
| 3.7         |  |
| 3.3         |  |
| 3.0         |  |
| 2.7         |  |
| 2.3         |  |

|     |  |
|-----|--|
| 2.0 |  |
| 1.0 |  |
| 0   |  |

### *Grade Appeals*

I am always happy to meet to discuss in further detail the criteria used for grading. Please come see me in office hours or make an appointment, if you would like to meet with me to clarify my standards and procedures. It is rare for me to change grades unless it was based on an error of calculation, which has happened on occasion. Academics place serious weight on the process of peer review, which is based on the ideas that qualified outsiders are the best judge of the quality and strength of work. If you would like to discuss or appeal your grade, please follow the process detailed below.

1. I will correct calculation errors, at any time with apologies.
2. Please set up an appointment or come to my office hours to seek explanation for a grade.

The most likely course of action will be to discuss improvement for subsequent assignments.

3. If a student wishes to dispute a grade, you may choose to follow the university's standard appeals process (note: if an appeal is heard at the university level, it is considered *sui generis*, meaning that the grade could stay the same, be raised or lowered and will be graded by another professor in the University).

### **EMAIL POLICY**

During the academic year, I receive a considerable amount of email. In order for me to respond to my email efficiently, please follow the following guidelines:

1. If you cannot see me during my office hours, email me to set up an appointment; I will try to respond as soon as possible but I usually cannot accommodate a meeting in 24 or even 48 hours.
2. I read and reply to email once a day and usually do not read or reply to email after 5 PM or weekends.
3. Grade inquiries and disputes will not be considered or discussed via email. For all grade inquiries and questions about assignments, please set up an appointment with me (see above).
4. I will not reply to email inquiries regarding course matters (assignment requirements, due dates, exam structure, readings, etc.) that arise from missing class or inattention to the course syllabus. Inquiries requesting clarification will receive replies, though I would strongly prefer these inquiries to be made in class or during office hours.

### **OTHER INFORMATION AND MCGILL POLICIES**

*Language:* In accord with McGill University's Charter of Students' Rights, students in this course

have the right to submit in English or in French any written work that is to be graded.

*Accommodations:* Students requiring special testing accommodations or other classroom modifications should notify Prof. Coleman and the Office for Students with Disabilities as soon as possible. The OSD is located in Suite 3100, Brown Student Services Building, ph: 398-6009 (voice), 398-8198 (TDD), [www.mcgill.ca/osd/](http://www.mcgill.ca/osd/).

*Academic Integrity:* McGill University values academic integrity. Therefore, all students must understand the meaning and consequences of cheating, plagiarism, and other academic offenses under the Code of Student Conduct and Disciplinary Procedures. (for more information, see [www.mcgill.ca/students/srr/honest/](http://www.mcgill.ca/students/srr/honest/).) L'université McGill attache une haute importance à l'honnêteté académique. Il incombe par conséquent à tous les étudiants de comprendre ce que l'on entend par tricherie, plagiat et autres infractions académiques, ainsi que les conséquences que peuvent avoir de telles actions, selon le Code de conduite de l'étudiant et des procédures disciplinaires (pour de plus amples renseignements, veuillez consulter le site [www.mcgill.ca/students/srr/honest/](http://www.mcgill.ca/students/srr/honest/)).

*Academic resources:* Students looking for additional assistance with academic reading, study, research and writing skills should consult the McGill academic resources website at: [www.mcgill.ca/students/academicresources/](http://www.mcgill.ca/students/academicresources/).

*Counseling:* McGill's Counseling Service provides extensive personal, academic, and career counseling to undergraduate and graduate students, including workshops on study skills, multiple-choice exams, text anxiety/stress management. They are located in Brown Student Services Bldg. 398-3601 [www.mcgill.ca/counseling/](http://www.mcgill.ca/counseling/). A list of groups and workshops can be found at: [www.mcgill.ca/counseling/groups/](http://www.mcgill.ca/counseling/groups/)

*Illness:* Students are responsible for material covered in all classes, including anything missed due to illness. Examinations will not be rescheduled and assignment due date extensions will not be provided, for any reason other than documented illness. Students unable to attend examinations or complete assignments due to illness are expected to contact me prior to the examination or due date by email and by phone. Appropriate documentation will be required to support requests for special consideration due to illness (see <http://www.mcgill.ca/students/advising/faq#a14>).

## **SCHEDULE**

The following is a "working schedule." *Class materials are subject to change* based on the interests, understanding, and general pace of the class. It is your responsibility to keep on top of any schedule changes, whether you are in class or not. If you have a concern about any of the materials, please speak to me or the teaching assistants.

## Week 1

### September 6: Pranking, Phreaks, and Tricksters

Ron Rosenbaum, "Secrets of the Little Blue Box." Esquire Magazine, October 1971.

<http://www.lospadres.info/thorg/lbb.html>

Kembrew McLeod, "Pranksters: Making Mischief in the Modern World." 2014. (chapters 1 and 6)

Phil Lapsley, "Exploding the Phone." 2013. (chapters 1 and 13)

*Graduate students:*

Lewis Hyde, "Trickster Makes this World: Mischief, Myth and Art." 2010. (Selections)

## Week 2

### September 13: The Internet, Early Hacking, and Historical Representation

Roy Rosenzweig, "Wizards, Bureaucrats, Warriors, and Hackers: Writing the History of the Internet." The American Historical Review, Dec. 1998.

<http://www.pne.people.si.umich.edu/PDF/ahrcwreview.pdf>

Steven Levy, "Hackers: Heroes of the Computer Revolution." 1984. (Sections of Part I)

Stephanie Ricker Schulte, "The 'WarGames Scenario': Regulating Teenagers and Teenaged Technology." Cached: Decoding the Internet in Global Popular Culture, 2013.

Molly Sauter, "Kevin Mitnick, the New York Times, and the Media's Conception of the Hacker." IAMCR, 2013.

*Graduate students:*

Kristin Ross, "May 68 and its Afterlives." 2002. (Introduction)

Tom Streeter, "Internet." Digital Keywords, ed. Benjamin Peters, 2016.

## Week 3

### September 20: Freeing Software, New Publics, and Boundary Objects

Christopher Kelty, "Two Bits: The Cultural Significance of Free Software." 2008. (chapter 4 and 6)

Tara McPherson, "U.S. Operating Systems at Mid-Century: The Intertwining of Race and UNIX." Race After the Internet, ed. Lisa Nakamura and Peter Chow-White, 2011.

Susan Leigh Star, "This is Not a Boundary Object: Reflections on the Origin of a Concept." Science, Technology, & Human Values, 2010.

<http://www.arch.mcgill.ca/prof/luka/urbandesignhousing/temp/other/isabelle/LeighStar2010.pdf>

*Graduate students:*

Michael Warner, "Publics and Counter Publics." Public Culture, Winter 2002.

[https://www.amherst.edu/system/files/Warner\\_o.pdf](https://www.amherst.edu/system/files/Warner_o.pdf)

## Week 4

### September 27: The Liberal Side of Hacking and Expertise

Andrew Schrock, "Civic hacking as data activism and advocacy: A history from publicity to open government data." *New Media and Society*, April 2016.

<http://nms.sagepub.com/content/early/2016/02/15/1461444816629469.abstract>

Gabriella Coleman, "Code Is Speech: Legal Tinkering, Expertise, and Protest among Free and Open Source Software Developers." *Cultural Anthropology*, August 2009.

<https://culanth.org/articles/89-code-is-speech-legal-tinkering-expertise-and>

Sebastian Kubitschko, "The Role of Hackers in Countering Surveillance and Promoting Democracy." *Media and Communication*, September 2015.

<http://www.cogitatiopress.com/ojs/index.php/mediaandcommunication/article/view/281>

Michael Schudson, "The Trouble with Experts—and Why Democracies Need Them." *Theory and Society*, December 2006. [http://www.jstor.org/stable/4501762?seq=1#page\\_scan\\_tab\\_contents](http://www.jstor.org/stable/4501762?seq=1#page_scan_tab_contents)

*Graduate students:*

Stuart Hall, "Variants of Liberalism." *Politics and ideology*, 1986.

Class Skype Visit: Paul Tagliamonte, White House Gov Hacker

## Week 5

### October 4: Hacking and Social Movements

Todd Wolfson, "Digital Rebellion: The Birth of the Cyber Left." 2014. (Chapter TBD)

John Postill, "Freedom technologists and the new protest movements: A theory of protest formulas." *Convergence*, November 2014. <http://con.sagepub.com/content/20/4/402>

*Graduate students:*

More of the Todd Wolfson, TBD.

Alison Powell, "Hacking in the public interest: Authority, legitimacy, means, and ends." *New Media & Society*, April 2016. <http://nms.sagepub.com/content/18/4/600>

## Week 6

### October 11: Digital Disobedience and Dissent

William E. Scheuerman, "Digital disobedience and the law." *New Political Science*, 2016.

<http://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/07393148.2016.1189027>

Gabriella Coleman, "From Internet Farming to Weapons of the Geek." *Current Anthropology*, Forthcoming.

Eric Hobsbawm, "The Machine Breakers." *Past and Present*, February 1952.

<http://web.csulb.edu/~ssayeghc/theory/wintertheory/machinebreakers.pdf>

*Graduate students:*

Marco Deseriis, *Improper Names: Collective Pseudonyms from the Luddites to Anonymous* (Introduction and Chapter 5).

## Week 7

### October 18: Pacifying Disruption

Johan Söderberg and Alessandro Delfanti, "Hacking Hacked! The Life Cycles of Digital Innovation." Science, Technology & Human Values, 2015.

<http://sth.sagepub.com/content/40/5/793.extract>

Benoît Godin, "Innovation: The History of a Category." 2008.

<http://www.csiic.ca/PDF/IntellectualNo1.pdf>

Alexa Clay and Kyra Maya Phillips, "The Misfit Economy: Lessons in Creativity from Pirates, Hackers, Gangsters and Other Informal Entrepreneurs." 2015. (Introduction and Chapter 4)

*Graduate students:*

TBD

## Week 8

### October 25: Security, Risk, Attribution and Deception

Sara Tocchetti and Sara Angeli Aguiton, "Is an FBI Agent a DIY Biologist Like Any Other? A Cultural Analysis of a Biosecurity Risk." Science, Technology & Human Values, September 2015.

<http://sth.sagepub.com/content/40/5/825.abstrac>

Thomas Rid and Ben Buchanan, "Attributing Cyber Attacks." Journal of Strategic Studies, 2014.

<http://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/01402390.2014.977382?af=R>

Frank Bajak and Jack Gillum, "Snapping up cheap spy tools, nations 'monitoring everyone.'" The Big Story, August 2, 2016.

<http://bigstory.ap.org/article/f799cfd080bo4b93a34df61fco07bo96/snapping-cheap-spy-tools-nations-monitoring-everyone>

**Class visit:** Security Hackers

*Graduate students:*

TBD

## Week 9

### November 1: Criminal Hacking , Deviance, and the Ethics of Illegality

Benoît Dupont et al., "The ecology of trust among hackers." Global Crime, 2016.

<http://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/17440572.2016.1157480?journalCode=fglc20>

Nicolas Auray and Danielle Kaminsky, "The professionalisation paths of hackers in IT security: The sociology of a divided identity." Annales Des Télécommunications, November 2007.

Kai T. Erikson, "Wayward Puritans: A Study in the Sociology of Deviance." 1966. (Chapter 1)

Kevin Poulsen, "Kingpin: How One Hacker Took Over the Billion-Dollar Cybercrime Underground." 2011. (Chapter TDB)



*Graduate Students:*

## **Week 10**

### **November 8: Hacking at the Margins and Infrastructure**

Erik Skare, "Digital Jihad: Palestinian Resistance in the Digital Era." 2016. (Chapter TBD)  
Lilly U Nguyen, "Infrastructural action in Vietnam: Inverting the techno-politics of hacking in the global South." *New Media & Society*, April 2016. <http://nms.sagepub.com/content/18/4/637>  
Brian Larkin, "The Politics and Poetics of Infrastructure." *Annual Review of Anthropology*, October 2013. <http://www.annualreviews.org/doi/abs/10.1146/annurev-anthro-092412-155522>

*Graduate students:*

TBD

## **Week 11**

### **November 15: Piracy**

Lawrence Liang, "Beyond Representation: The Figure of the Pirate." *Access to Knowledge in the Age of Intellectual Property*, ed. Gaëlle Krikorian and Amy Kapczynski, 2010.  
Kavita Philip, "Keep on Copyin' in the Free World? Genealogies of the Postcolonial Pirate Figure." *Postcolonial Piracy: Media Distribution and Cultural Production in the Global South*, ed. Lars Eckstein and Anja Schwarz, 2014.  
Balázs Bodó, "The Common Pathways of Samizdat and Piracy." *Samizdat*, ed. V. Parisi, 2015. [http://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract\\_id=2672802](http://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=2672802)

*Graduate Students:*

TBD

## **Week 12**

### **November 22: Critical Trolling**

Matt Goerzen, "Critical Trolling." M.A. Thesis.  
Keller Easterling, "Extrastatecraft: The Power of Infrastructure Space." 2014. (Chapter 6)  
Whitney Phillips (TBD)

**Class visit:** Matt Goerzen

## **Week 13**

### **November 29: Anonymous and Obfuscation**

Phillip Rogaway, "The Moral Character of Cryptographic Work." *Asiacrypt* 2015.



<http://web.cs.ucdavis.edu/~rogaway/papers/moral-fn.pdf>

Édouard Glissant, "Poetics of Relation." 1990. [http://shifter-magazine.com/wp-content/uploads/2015/10/Glissant\\_For\\_Opacity.pdf](http://shifter-magazine.com/wp-content/uploads/2015/10/Glissant_For_Opacity.pdf)

Adam Morris, "Whoever, Whatever: On Anonymity as Resistance to Empire." Parallax, 2012. <http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/13534645.2012.714560>

Gabriella Coleman, "Epilogue: The State of Anonymous." Hacker, Hoaxer, Whistleblower, Spy, 2015. <http://gabriellacoleman.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/11/hhws-epilogue-extract.pdf>

